
Digital Sickle Cell Care Plan

Board briefing: progress and a request for support

To: Board of the NHS Race & Health Observatory **From:** Dr Carl Reynolds, Clinical Advisor **Date:** July 2026

Recommendation. The Board is asked to (1) note the progress set out below; (2) approve the anticipated funding requirement of £300,000 to £600,000 for the initial phase; and (3) support the programme in securing an NHS acute trust partner and a Memorandum of Understanding.

Progress to date

- **Discovery research.** In 2022 to 2023, with Public Digital and University Hospitals Bristol and Weston, the Observatory ran digital discovery research into acute sickle cell care. The resulting *Sickle Cell Digital Discovery Report (2023)* recommended that **personalised digital care plans be explored further**.
- **Technical scoping.** Follow-on work was commissioned to understand the technical requirements of building a personalised digital sickle cell care plan.
- **Vertex partnership.** The partnership with Vertex Pharmaceuticals, which the Board previously supported, has secured **£60,000 of external funding to date**, against a total request of approximately **£1 million**. A progress report to Vertex is due on **8 August 2026**, after which we will submit a further funding application. Vertex has no role in the design, content or delivery of the programme.
- **Prototype and website.** A functional, open-source **prototype** and a **project website** are live. This is a working service, not a concept on paper, and substantially de-risks delivery. Prototype: digital-sickle.carlreynolds.net · Website: carlreynolds.net/digital-sickle
- **Complementary to London's Universal Care Plan (UCP).** The service is designed to complement and interoperate with UCP, not compete with it: it is open-source with public-domain intellectual property, purpose-built for the acute painful crisis and the NICE 30-minute standard, builds accountability into the product, and provides the whole service across the majority of England where UCP does not operate.
- **Engagement.** We have engaged NHS England, the Royal College of Emergency Medicine, the National Haematology Pain Group, patients with lived experience, and other healthcare professionals.

Current position and next steps

We are now seeking one NHS acute trust to partner with us and sign a **Memorandum of Understanding**; **Bristol, Manchester and Homerton** are our leading candidates. **We would welcome the Board's support in securing this partner.** With an MoU in place, we will run an **invitation to tender (ITT)** for a digital delivery partner. Softwire and dxw are strong candidates and have already been approached informally.

The ask

The budgetary requirement depends on confirmation of Vertex and NHS partner funding. The full project is costed at around **£600,000**; a reduced **£300,000** scope is our contingency to deliver a smaller stand-alone service should Vertex or NHS partner funding fall short. Either way, this initial phase completes **before March 2027** and delivers a stand-alone, workable digital service.